

SMU - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-25 baseline with ACC-title upside, but more volatile than the veteran-QB headline suggests.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 19 (434 points) · ACC media ACC No. 2 (2,794 points; 6 first-place votes) · SP+ No. 25
Returning production	62% (No. 23) overall · Off. 66% (No. 21) · Def. 58% (No. 42)
Primer power rating	+12.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	8.3 wins · likely 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar overall quality, with more roster volatility
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: SMU should still be driven by the continuity of Rhett Lashlee and established QB Kevin Jennings, with three returning offensive-line anchors supporting a rebuilt group of backs, receivers and tight ends.

Bottom line: SMU has a credible top-25/ACC-contender baseline because the quarterback, staff and core offensive line are stable, but repeating nine wins depends on a large wave of new skill players and defenders replacing unusually concentrated 2025 production.

Beats expectations if: QB Kevin Jennings quickly organizes the rebuilt receiver/TE group, C Joshua Bates/OG Addison Nichols/OT PJ Williams keep negative plays down, and the new front preserves 2025 havoc and explosive prevention.

Disappoints if: The loss of four top pass catchers and the top four sack producers creates a longer transition than the returning-production headline implies, leaving QB Kevin Jennings under-supported and the defense unable to generate pressure with a rebuilt secondary behind it.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Kevin Jennings is the established starter; the throwing-hand finger issue was temporary and was not expected to threaten the opener.
- 2 Receiver reset:** SMU replaces four of its top five 2025 pass catchers, so the offense is simultaneously experienced at QB and highly new at the skill positions.
- 3 ★ OT PJ Williams:** OT PJ Williams and C Joshua Bates are first-team preseason All-ACC selections and anchor a line that returns three starters.
- 4 Pass-rush turnover:** The defense lost its top four 2025 sack producers even though last year's unit ranked No. 24 in havoc created and No. 22 in explosive-play prevention.
- 5 ? Roster-status nuance:** S Ahmaad Moses is not a settled 2026 return, and RB T.J. Harden's NFL-to-portal chronology must not be flattened into a normal SMU transfer departure.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	9-4 (6-2 ACC)	● Good
Scoring	32.2 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	416.9 YPG	● Very good
Rush offense	133.8 YPG · 4.3 YPC	● Below average
Pass efficiency	8.00 YPA · 26 TD / 13 INT	● Very good
Third downs	40.8%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	20.5 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	395.1 YPG allowed	● Below average
Rush defense	111.9 YPG · 3.2 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	283.2 YPG · 7.05 YPA · 26 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

SMU paired a strong passing/scoring offense (No. 26 scoring, No. 31 total, No. 35 pass efficiency) with a weak rushing rank (No. 95). The defense kept points and rushing production down (No. 31 scoring defense, No. 19 rush defense) despite finishing No. 89 in total defense and only No. 56 in pass-efficiency defense.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+5.02 · No. 21	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.074 · No. 39	● Good / above average
Off. success rate	42.9% · No. 63	● Average / mixed
Off. explosive-play rate	12.4% · No. 60	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	16.4% · No. 90	● Below average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+4.01 · No. 29	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.072 · No. 38	● Good / above average
Def. success rate allowed	39.5% · No. 39	● Good / above average
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	9.8% · No. 22	● Very good
Havoc created	17.7% · No. 24	● Very good

Advanced-stat read: SMU was stronger than the raw total-defense rank suggests: both adjusted units were top 30, and the defense prevented explosives and created havoc well. The main warning was No. 90 havoc allowed.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC / offensive play-caller	Rhett Lashlee - returning; will call offensive plays	● ↔ Offensive play-calling continuity supports the unit baseline
Co-OC structure	◆ Rob Likens / Garin Justice / D'Eriq King - Likens and Justice return; King is internally promoted to co-OC/QB	● ↔ New role creates upside with normal transition risk
Co-DC / defensive play-caller	◆ Maurice Crum Jr. - returning co-DC with newly explicit 2026 defensive play-calling duty	● ↔ Defensive play-calling responsibility is settled within the staff
Co-DC / secondary	Rickey Hunley Jr. - returning same role	● ↔ Continuity supports a stable preseason projection

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Kendrick Raphael	California	● ↔ Projected lead back with Doak Walker recognition, replacing proven 2025 rushing production.
◆ WR Yannick Smith	East Carolina	● ↔ First-group candidate helping replace four of the top five 2025 pass catchers.
◆ WR Jalen Hale	Alabama	● ↔ Meaningful receiver addition with comeback recognition.
◆ TE Randy Pittman Jr.	Florida State	● ↔ Expected starter with Mackey recognition replacing major TE losses.

Out	To	Loss
RB T.J. Harden	NFL (Cleveland / Seattle), undrafted free agent; later portal destination not established	● ↓ The 2025 leading rusher leaves; later portal entry does not change the initial NFL-departure chronology.
WR Jordan Hudson	NFL (Dallas), undrafted free agent	● ↓ The 2025 receiving-yardage leader leaves.
WR Romello Brinson	NFL (Dallas), undrafted free agent	● ↓ A 10-start, 638-yard receiver departs; the later waiver does not erase the NFL departure.
TE Matthew Hibner	NFL (Baltimore), Round 4, No. 133	● ↓ A 13-start, 436-yard tight end was drafted.
OL Logan Parr	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ A 12-start first-team All-ACC lineman leaves with no confirmed destination.

Offensive net: Similar ceiling with substantially more newcomer dependence

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL Malcolm Alcorn-Crowder	Kansas State	● ↔ Likely first-unit interior piece in a rebuilt front.
◆ DL Christian Davis	Louisiana Tech	● ↔ Expected first-unit addition; replacing the old front's disruption remains unproven.
◆ DE Marques White	Massachusetts	● ↔ In line for a major edge role after heavy pass-rush turnover.
◆ S Jimmy Wyrick	UTSA	● ↔ Anticipated starting safety in a secondary replacing veteran production.

Out	To	Loss
S Isaiah Nwokobia	NFL (Cincinnati), undrafted free agent	● ↓ A 12-start, 80-tackle safety leaves.
CB Deuce Harmon	Undrafted; no NFL signing established	● ↓ A 13-start corner leaves with no confirmed professional destination.

Out	To	Loss
DE Billy Walton III	Oklahoma State	● ↓ His 2025 edge/front production leaves as part of a group replacing its top four sack producers.
EDGE DJ Warner	Washington State	● ↓ Pass-rush turnover grows for a 2025 defense that relied on havoc.

Defensive net: Likely step back in continuity, with transfer talent preserving a functional ceiling

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Continuity offense built around established QB Kevin Jennings and a three-starter OL core.	QB Kevin Jennings, OT PJ Williams, C Joshua Bates and OG Addison Nichols provide high-leverage continuity; 2025 opponent-adjusted offense was No. 21.	Four top pass catchers are gone, the run game ranked No. 95 in 2025, and havoc allowed ranked No. 90.
Defense	A Crum-called defense trying to preserve 2025 disruption, run defense and explosive-play prevention with a heavily reworked front and secondary.	2025 opponent-adjusted defense No. 29, rush defense No. 19, explosive prevention No. 22 and havoc created No. 24 establish a strong schematic/performance baseline.	The top four sack producers and multiple veteran defensive backs are gone, while corner/rover/nickel roles remain unsettled.
Special teams	New projected specialists with a weak SP+ special-teams signal.	The team profile identifies clear current front-runners at kicker and punter rather than an unresolved three-way competition.	The new specialist operation is not established as an upgrade; the model ranks it No. 104.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B+	● ↔	High	QB Kevin Jennings gives the offense established third-year continuity
RB	● B–	● ↔	Medium-low	RB Kendrick Raphael leads a room replacing the top two 2025 rushers
WR	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	WR Yamir Knight leads a room replacing four of the top five 2025 pass catchers
TE	● B–	● ↓	Medium	TE Randy Pittman Jr. and TE Theo Melin Ohrstrom replace two pro-football departures
OL	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	OT PJ Williams, C Joshua Bates and OG Addison Nichols are strong anchors
DL/Edge	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	EDGE Aakil Washington returns and multiple transfers project into major roles.
LB	● B–	● ↔	Medium	Projected starters return, but veteran losses and LB Ahmad Walker availability limit certainty
Secondary	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	CB Marcellus Barnes Jr. and S Jimmy Wyrick help offset major losses; S Ahmaad Moses cannot be counted active
Special teams	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	K Nick Reed and P Sam McSparron project to start; SP+ ranks the unit No. 104
Coaching	● A–	● ↔	Medium-high	Lashlee remains HC/offensive caller, the offensive staff is largely continuous.
Overall	● B+	● ↔	Medium-low	SP+ No. 25 and poll support fit a strong Power Four/top-30 profile, but heavy two-sided newcomer dependence lowers stability.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through August 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Kevin Jennings	QB	● High-end conference starter / national-watchlist QB	Maxwell Award · Walter Camp Player of the Year	The established starter is the biggest reason SMU can absorb major skill turnover without resetting the offense.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
PJ Williams	OT	● High-end conference starter	ACC Preseason Team: first team · Outland Trophy	Returning right-tackle anchor and one of the strongest continuity pieces on the roster.
Joshua Bates	C	● High-end conference starter	ACC Preseason Team: first team · Outland Trophy · Rimington Trophy	Center anchor whose continuity matters more because two other OL spots remain unsettled.
Yamir Knight	WR	● Solid-to-high-end conference starter	-	Leading returning receiver after 54 catches, 637 yards and five TDs; the rebuilt pass-catcher hierarchy starts with him.
◆ Kendrick Raphael (TR: California)	RB	● Projected high-end Power Four starter	Doak Walker Award	Projected lead back charged with replacing the departed top two rushers.
◆ Randy Pittman Jr. (TR: Florida State)	TE	● Projected high-end conference starter	John Mackey Award	Projected first tight end and a key replacement for two pro-football departures.
Marcellus Barnes Jr.	CB	● Solid Power Four starter	-	The most settled corner in a secondary with open jobs opposite him and at rover/nickel.
Aakil Washington	EDGE	● High-upside returning rotation piece	-	Returns from a 2025 medical redshirt into a front replacing the top four sack producers; his re-emergence could materially change the pass-rush ceiling.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Moderate by national standards, but the two early road tests and late Notre Dame trip create clear leverage points for an ACC contender.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · SP+ SOS No. 52
Hardest stretch	Virginia Tech → Wake Forest → at Notre Dame; the finale is a road trip to SP+ No. 3
Swing games	at Florida State, at Louisville, Virginia Tech
Advantage	Seven home games plus a bye before the Virginia/California portion of the ACC schedule give SMU recovery and home-field opportunities after the opening road tests.
Expected	8.3 wins · likely 8-4
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	AP No. 19 and ACC No. 2 create a stronger public/poll story than SP+ No. 25, so the main preseason risk is paying a contender premium before the rebuilt skill/front groups prove they are plug-and-play.
Back them when	When the price is closer to a top-25 baseline than a top-15 narrative and the matchup lets QB Kevin Jennings operate behind his veteran OL anchors without exposing the new receivers to constant obvious-passing-down stress.
Fade/pass when	When SMU is laying a premium against a strong pressure front or a capable passing offense before the new edge/secondary rotation proves it can replace 2025 disruption and veteran coverage.
Key monitor	QB Kevin Jennings finger status, LT/LG competitions, receiver hierarchy, new front production, secondary winners, LB Ahmad Walker timeline, S Ahmaad Moses eligibility/clearance/roster status
Week 1 baseline	SMU -1.0 at Florida State · rating-only baseline; SMU primer +12.0 minus Florida State primer +9.0 minus 2.0 default road/home-field adjustment; no matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: SMU -2.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

SMU's top-25 case starts with QB Kevin Jennings, Rhett Lashlee and three veteran OL anchors. The uncertainty sits around them: the pass-catcher hierarchy and much of the defensive front/secondary must replace concentrated 2025 production.

The baseline is 8.3 wins and 8-4, with legitimate ACC-contender upside. AP No. 19 and ACC No. 2 can create a premium, so the best value should come when the price respects SP+ No. 25 and the rebuilt groups still have something to prove.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [team preview](#) · [fall camp](#) · [QB update](#) · [comeback watchlist](#) · [NFL departure](#) · [RB eligibility](#) · [DB status](#)

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